

Episode 71: Extra Edition – Finally Complete! *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!*

How many floors up do you use the elevator?

I live on the 4th floor of a 6-story apartment building, and when going up and down from the 1st floor to my home, I end up taking the elevator. Well, having the elevator right by my apartment door is a big reason I keep taking it (laughs).

Somehow I seem to have a rule in my head that goes "stairs for up to 3 floors, elevator for 4 floors and above." I wonder why?

The elementary and junior high schools I attended as a child were 3-story buildings. The school I went to every day naturally had stairs up to the 3rd floor, so I unknowingly developed this "stairs up to 3 floors" rule, I suppose?

What do you think?

Wait... my high school was 4 stories (sweat).

Incidentally, Toei Animation's (東映アニメーション) Oizumi Studio is basically a 3-story building. It feels more like a school than a company, you know? My desk is on the 2nd floor, and every time I need to check rushes, I go up to the screening room on the 3rd floor... I'd kind of like an escalator (laughs).

Now then.

This is the third promotional extra edition for the theatrical work *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!* (劇場版 ゲゲゲの鬼太郎 日本爆裂！！) opening this month (December 20th) (laughs).

As I wrote last time, after creating the colours for the regular characters by modifying the existing TV version character colours, and the theatrical original characters, we now move on to matching these with the background art for each scene and confirming the colour scheme for each scene.

When I get worked up thinking "theatrical work," I tend to overdo things, but this time there was an agreement with Director Koga (古賀監督) and the producer to "not stray too far from the TV series." With that in mind, I started organising the scenes, so I aimed for relatively normal-looking screens. Even so, since it's a theatrical version, we also aimed for dynamic screens worthy of that, which was the tricky part.

Roughly speaking, I placed the so-called "normal" colour direction (色指定) - the most basic standard - on the daytime outdoor scenes.

For the several sunset scenes, I created a total of 8 different sunset colour directions to match the depth of each sunset.

Similarly, I made 4 types of night colour direction. Additionally, I created quite a few colour schemes for special locations and time periods like the Yokai Yokocho, a certain cave interior, the hell realm where Enma-sama resides, and various flashback image scenes.

As for the light effects during battle scenes and reflection effects, those colours were handled almost entirely on a cut-by-cut basis. Oh, and the familiar BANK cuts from the TV version were naturally adjusted in colour to match their use in this theatrical production.

Since the climax scene took place at night, I created night-like colours for the cels, but here too there was an order from the director to "not make it too dark, use colours that still convey the characters' normal colour feel," so I created quite clean night colours.

For daytime scenes inside Kitaro's house and Hana's mansion, I had them coloured with the "normal" colour direction first, then made adjustments during cel inspection. I placed the cels on the backgrounds for those cuts and slightly adjusted the brightness.

That's right, this time I handled both the colour direction and final cel inspection alone for the entire production (for the colouring inspection, several staff members did rough inspections of the overseas colouring before I checked them), so I worked on adjusting cel colours by matching them with backgrounds before sending them to photography.

Based on predetermined scene colour directions, we specify colours for each accordingly, but even then, depending on the cut, there are various elements like the amount of shadows in the drawings, the brightness or darkness expression of the backgrounds, the particular performance content we want to achieve in that cut, so it often doesn't work to simply say "this scene's colours are OK if painted with this colour direction."

So I actually place the cels on the backgrounds and make small adjustments to brightness and colour tone so each cut achieves the intended screen balance.

Some productions have separate specialised staff who handle such adjustment work using After Effects, but for this *Kitaro*, I was allowed to create quite a lot of the screens myself.

And we mustn't forget the work of the special effects department. Most texture processing and effects are the work of the special effects team. For hand-drawn animation, their section's work is indispensable! This time too, they thought through various processing techniques and completed an enormous amount of work. Even during the aforementioned fine-tuning adjustments, they properly handled my selfish orders like "ah, actually here, add some brush work..." (laughs).

Animation production workflow is an assembly line process. After the key animation is finished and the animation director's work is done, the final 7 days from when the last

cut reaches me becomes the final battle. Everything must be finished in these 7 days. We accelerate all at once toward completion. How many cuts can get rush approval before entering these "7 days of fire" (笑) becomes one major key in the final push of theatrical production (laughs).

This time the coordination between sections went well, and we managed to get through without major confusion. Phew, that was good! If these gears had gotten out of sync, we might have faced a situation where we'd have to tearfully give up on major retakes that remained at the end. But this time we were able to finish with results that satisfied the staff.

So anyway, I managed to give final approval to all cuts about 12 hours before writing this manuscript. Now we just wait for the first screening at the lab.

The short film *GeGeGe Festival! The Five Great Kitaros* and *GeGeGe no Kitaro the Movie: Japan Explodes!!* - just over 2 weeks until everyone can see them (oh, there seems to be an advance screening next weekend). Please look forward to it!

(08.12.02)